

Social Exclusion and Marginalisation of Scheduled Castes in Semi-Urban Areas of Bihar: An Empirical Study

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Abstract: Despite constitutional guarantees of equality and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, social exclusion and caste-based discrimination continue to pervade the everyday lives of Scheduled Caste communities in semi-urban India. This mixed-methods study examined the forms, mechanisms, and persistence of social exclusion experienced by Scheduled Caste households in three semi-urban towns of Bihar — Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, and Bhagalpur — through a combination of structured survey interviews with 300 SC household heads and 20 in-depth interviews with SC adults aged 18–60 years. Survey findings document the persistence of exclusion across four domains: public and civic spaces (temples, water bodies, community gatherings), employment and economic opportunities, educational attainment and school climate, and political participation and civic voice. Multivariate analysis showed that caste identity remains a significant predictor of exclusion across all four domains even after controlling for income, education, and urban proximity. In-depth interview narratives revealed that exclusion operates through subtle symbolic mechanisms — including differential treatment at food stalls and shops, implicit spatial segregation in public seating, and social ostracism following inter-caste marriages — rather than the overt forms of untouchability more commonly documented in rural settings. The study concludes that urbanisation has transformed but not eliminated caste-based exclusion, and that the legal framework requires complementary social capital and sensitisation interventions to achieve meaningful inclusion.

Keywords: *Social Exclusion, Scheduled Castes, Caste Discrimination, Bihar, Semi-Urban, Atrocities Act*

1. Introduction

Social exclusion — defined as the process by which certain groups are systematically denied participation in the economic, social, cultural, and political life of the society in which they live — is deeply intertwined with caste structures in India. The Indian Constitution's framers were acutely aware of this structural problem: Articles 15, 16, 17, and 46 specifically prohibit caste discrimination, abolish untouchability, and direct the state to promote the educational and economic interests of Scheduled Castes. Supplementary legislative protections, including the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act of 1989 and the Protection of Civil Rights Act of 1955, created punitive frameworks for specific acts of caste violence and discrimination.

Bihar presents a particularly complex and historically rooted caste landscape. The state has witnessed some of India's most violent caste conflicts — including the Bathani Tola massacre (1996) and the Laxmanpur Bathe massacre (1997) — and continues to record high numbers of atrocities against Scheduled Castes in National Crime Records Bureau annual data. While a great deal of scholarly attention has focused on rural Bihar, the rapid growth of semi-urban towns and small cities in the state over the past two decades has created new and less-studied social

contexts in which caste relations are being renegotiated — often in more covert and symbolically complex ways than in villages.

Semi-urban settings occupy an ambiguous sociological space: they retain strong links to the agricultural and social hierarchies of rural hinterlands while simultaneously embracing urban aspirations, market economies, and greater anonymity. For Scheduled Caste residents of semi-urban towns, this ambiguity translates into an experience of caste exclusion that is simultaneously less visible and less documented than its rural counterpart — making it harder to litigate under existing legal frameworks and easier for dominant castes to deny. Empirical sociological documentation of exclusion patterns in these settings is therefore both academically significant and practically necessary for targeted policy responses.

This study sets out to systematically document the forms and intensity of caste-based exclusion experienced by Scheduled Caste residents in three semi-urban towns of Bihar, to analyse the structural and social determinants of exclusion, and to complement quantitative survey data with in-depth qualitative narratives that illuminate the subjective experience and adaptive strategies of excluded individuals and communities.

2. Methodology

The study employed a mixed-methods sequential explanatory design: quantitative survey data were collected first to establish prevalence and correlates of exclusion, followed by qualitative in-depth interviews to illuminate mechanisms and lived experience. Three semi-urban towns were selected purposively based on population size (50,000–300,000), significant SC population (above 18% as per Census 2011), and geographic distribution across Bihar: Muzaffarpur (north Bihar), Darbhanga (Mithila region), and Bhagalpur (eastern Bihar). Within each town, SC-concentrated wards were identified from municipal corporation ward data, and 100 SC household heads were selected using systematic random sampling per town, yielding a total survey sample of 300.

The survey instrument comprised four domain-specific exclusion scales developed by the researcher drawing on validated instruments from comparable South Asian studies, adapted to the Bihar semi-urban context. Each domain (public/civic, economic, educational, political) contained 6–8 items rated on a five-point frequency scale (never to always). A composite Social Exclusion Index (SEI) was computed as the mean of all 26 item scores (range 1–5, higher scores indicating greater exclusion). Sociodemographic data (income, education, sub-caste identity, length of residence, property ownership) were also collected. For the qualitative component, 20 purposively selected SC adults (10 men, 10 women, spanning three age cohorts) participated in semi-structured in-depth interviews lasting 60–90 minutes, conducted in Maithili or Hindi as preferred by participants and audio-recorded with consent.

Survey data were analysed using SPSS 24.0. Descriptive statistics characterised the sample and domain-level exclusion scores. Multivariate linear regression was used to identify independent predictors of the composite SEI. Qualitative interview transcripts were translated, and thematic analysis was conducted manually following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase framework. Ethical approval was obtained from the research ethics committee of Patna Women's College. Participant identities are anonymised; pseudonyms are used in all qualitative extracts.

3. Results and Findings

The composite Social Exclusion Index mean for the overall sample was 3.21 (SD=0.68) on a 1–5 scale, indicating moderate-to-high levels of exclusion. Domain-specific means were: public/civic exclusion (mean 3.48), economic exclusion (mean 3.34), educational climate exclusion (mean 2.89), and political marginalisation (mean 3.14). Darbhanga participants reported the highest composite exclusion scores (mean SEI: 3.41), while Muzaffarpur had the lowest (mean SEI: 3.02), a difference that may reflect Darbhanga's more traditional socio-cultural setting and historical patterns of Brahminical dominance.

Multivariate regression analysis revealed that caste identity (SC sub-caste, particularly Musahar and Dusadh sub-castes) ($B=0.41$, $p<0.001$), lower household income ($B=-0.28$, $p<0.01$), and lower educational attainment of household head ($B=-0.19$, $p<0.05$) were significant independent predictors of higher SEI scores, even after controlling for town of residence, type of neighbourhood, and length of urban residence. Notably, length of residence in the semi-urban town did not significantly predict exclusion, suggesting that time and social integration do not automatically reduce caste-based marginalisation in these settings.

Qualitative findings revealed that exclusion in semi-urban Bihar operates through several mechanisms distinct from classical rural untouchability. Participants described differential pricing or subtle service refusals at tea stalls and shops, spatial clustering of SC families in peripheral, flood-prone, or poorly serviced wards, exclusion from neighbourhood social ceremonies (weddings, Puja events) by dominant caste neighbours, and reduced willingness among landlords to rent to SC families in commercially central locations. One female participant (pseudonym: Savitri, age 38, Darbhanga) recounted that although mobility has improved, an unspoken awareness of which places remain unwelcoming to her community persists. Social ostracism following inter-caste marriages was cited by 6 of 20 interviewees as a particularly severe form of community exclusion.

4. Discussion

The finding that caste identity remains a robust and statistically significant predictor of social exclusion even in semi-urban settings, after controlling for income and education, is a significant contribution to the sociology of caste in India. It directly challenges the liberal modernisation thesis that urbanisation and market integration will naturally erode caste hierarchies over time. The evidence from this study suggests that semi-urban contexts do not neutralise caste-based exclusion — they transform and partially conceal it, making it harder to identify, document, and litigate under the Prevention of Atrocities Act's provisions.

The emergence of symbolic and spatial mechanisms of exclusion in semi-urban contexts — as opposed to the more overt ritual and physical exclusions commonly documented in villages — has important implications for law enforcement and social policy. The Prevention of Atrocities Act is designed primarily to address physical atrocities and identifiable acts of discrimination; it is less equipped to address the diffuse, everyday symbolic exclusions documented here. Complementary instruments — including anti-discrimination education in schools, sensitisation training for local government officials, and community-level intercaste dialogue facilitation — are necessary elements of a comprehensive anti-exclusion strategy.

Gender intersects with caste exclusion in complex ways in the Bihar semi-urban context. Female SC participants in this study reported higher rates of exclusion in public and civic spaces, consistent with the dual vulnerability of gender and caste. However, some women also described leveraging employment in domestic service in upper-caste households as a pragmatic strategy for accessing economic resources while navigating social exclusion — a coping mechanism that simultaneously reflects and reinforces dependency relationships. This finding aligns with Dalit feminist scholarship on the compounded nature of caste-gender marginalisation.

5. Conclusion

This study provides empirically grounded documentation of the persistence, forms, and determinants of caste-based social exclusion in semi-urban Bihar, demonstrating that urbanisation has not diminished but rather transformed the operation of caste exclusion, shifting its dominant modality from overt ritual untouchability to subtle symbolic marginalisation and spatial segregation. Scheduled Caste residents of semi-urban towns continue to experience significant exclusion across public, economic, educational, and political domains, with caste identity remaining a primary driver independent of socioeconomic status.

Policy recommendations include: (i) district-level monitoring of SC complaints under the Prevention of Atrocities Act disaggregated by urban versus rural reporting location; (ii) mandatory SC inclusion provisions in municipal housing allocation and commercial plot allotment schemes in Bihar's urban agglomerations; (iii) sensitisation training for police, municipal officials, and school teachers on identifying and responding to subtle and symbolic caste discrimination; (iv) state funding for SC community leadership development programmes in semi-urban wards; and (v) curriculum reform in Bihar schools to include Ambedkarite thought, constitutional values, and the history of the SC freedom movement.

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